Reaction and response

Most scientists greeted Farman's discovery with alarm: the potential increase in UV radiation would make skin cancers, cataracts, and sunburn far more prevalent.

What could be done? One reason for ozone depletion had been identified in 1974 by American scientists Frank Rowland and Mario Molina. They had concluded that gases containing chlorine—including the chlorofluorocarbons (CFCs) used in aerosol sprays and halogen refrigerants—were, in the presence of UV light, reacting with ozone in the stratosphere and breaking down the gas. A few countries, including the US, banned the use of these products, but most were yet to be convinced.

When ozone levels continued to fall throughout the 1980s, opinion gradually changed. Consequently, in 1987, the Montreal Protocol for a global ban was agreed. The ozone layer is showing signs of recovery, and it is hoped that by 2066, stratospheric ozone levels will return to pre-1980s values.